3.2 Increasing Regional Tensions

When people find it impossible to agree, they may need to work out a compromise to resolve the issue. In the early 1800s, Americans wanted to maintain a balance of power between free states and slave states, so they came up with a compromise.

MAIN IDEA As the United States expanded its territory and its power, it negotiated how each new state would deal with the issue of slavery.



THE MISSOURI COMPROMISE

Nationalism grew during the years of Madison's and Monroe's presidencies, and so did **sectionalism**. Sectionalism is the identification with and loyalty to a particular part of the country, such as the North or the South. The rise of sectionalism was driven by two main factors: the different economies of these regions and the practice of slavery. For the most part, the North was an industrial region, with mills and wage laborers, while the South was an agricultural region, producing cotton through slave labor.

The federal government wanted to admit the Missouri Territory as the 23rd state. The trick was how to do so without upsetting the balance of 11 slave states and 11 free states. Americans worried that admitting Missouri would create an imbalance in power between slave and free states. In 1819, the Senate proposed the **Missouri Compromise**. In it, the people of the state of Missouri could own slaves. Missouri would be admitted to the Union at the same time as Maine, a free state, which maintained the balance between the number of slave states and free states. The compromise prohibited slavery in all the lands acquired in the Louisiana Purchase north of the 36° 30' N latitude line. These lands were considered **unorganized territory**, or lands governed by the federal government but not belonging to any state. As

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a result of the compromise, any states formed from this unorganized territory would be free states. Even so, the compromise stated that enslaved people who escaped to free states could be captured and returned to their owners.

THE MONROE DOCTRINE

In December 1823, President Monroe delivered a speech in which he introduced a new approach to foreign policy. In it he stated, "The American continents, by the free and independent conditions which they have assumed and maintained, are henceforth not to be considered as subjects for future colonization by any European power." Monroe also promised that the United States would not fight in any European wars. In simple terms, the president said, "You stay out of our hemisphere, and we'll stay out of yours." His ideas became known as the **Monroe Doctrine**. Monroe warned European nations against interfering in the Western Hemisphere. Doing so would be considered an act of aggression that would result in military action from the United States. Monroe's declaration was bold because the United States had no actual authority over Central America or South America.

Part of the inspiration for the Monroe Doctrine stemmed from colonies in Central and South America rebelling against European rule. Monroe was concerned about European countries having so much presence and authority in Central and South America. He feared that European countries might try to re-assert their colonial power. He also had concerns over Russia's presence in what is now Alaska. Russia had issued a statement in 1821 that non-Russians could not enter its territory. Monroe did not want Russia to try to expand its North American territory.

Though Russia and Spain denounced the Monroe Doctrine, they tolerated it. Wars among European countries had wearied them, and they had little desire to expand their involvement in the Americas.



The Monroe Doctrine Desk

While serving as a minister to France under President George Washington, James Monroe purchased this mahogany desk in Paris. When he moved into the White House in 1817, he brought this desk with him and likely wrote the Monroe Doctrine while sitting at it. About 100 years after his presidency, Monroe's great-great-grandson discovered letters from Washington, Madison, Franklin, and Jefferson to Monroe, hidden in the desk's secret compartment.

HISTORICAL THINKING

1. **READING CHECK** What was Monroe's concern about Central and South America?
2. **IDENTIFY PROBLEMS AND SOLUTIONS** How did the Missouri Compromise attempt to solve a problem and cause a potential problem at the same time?
3. **INTERPRET MAPS** Based on details you notice on the map, what territories were open to slavery and what territories were closed to slavery?

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